

EYE OF PORTO



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THE LOCAL'S GUIDE

# Porto in *3 Days*

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by *Luís* — a Porto local, behind the wheel and behind this guide

SEE THE CITY LIKE A LOCAL · PORTO, PORTUGAL

# A note from a local

Before the lists and the maps — why this guide is different from the others on your phone.

I was born in Porto and I've lived here for over thirty years. For a living, I drive people around the city, and the same questions come up in every car: *Where do locals actually eat? What do I see if I only have a day? What should I skip?* This guide is the answer I'd give you if you were in my back seat.

It isn't trying to list everything — the big sites already do that, and badly. It's trying to do the one thing they can't: tell you the truth. Where the view is worth the climb and where it isn't. Which famous spot is a tourist trap and what the locals do instead. The small, unglamorous tips that turn a good trip into a great one.

## Local tip

Porto is small and walkable, but it's built on hills. Wear real shoes, not the ones for the photos. Your knees will thank me by Day 2.

## How to use it

Three days, each with a rhythm: morning, midday, afternoon, evening. Follow it to the letter, or pull out the parts you like — it's built to be remixed. Distances are short; nothing in a day is more than a 20-minute walk or a couple of metro stops from the last thing.

## Good to know

Opening hours and prices change, and Porto changes fast. The figures here were right when this was written — always glance at the live guide before you go. It stays current: [eyeofporto.github.io](https://eyeofporto.github.io).



LUÍS · PORTO

# Before you go

Five minutes here saves you an hour of confusion later.

## Getting in from the airport

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Porto airport sits on the metro's **Violet line (E)**, a straight ~30-minute ride to the centre (Trindade). The airport is in Zone 4, so a single trip costs about €2.30 on top of the card. A taxi or rideshare to the centre runs roughly €20–30 depending on traffic and time.

## The Andante card — your key to the city

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One rechargeable card works on metro, buses and urban trains. Buy a blue **Andante Azul** card for €0.60 at any machine, then load trips onto it. Central Porto is Zone 2: a single Z2 trip is €1.40. Validate before every ride — tap the card on the reader on the platform or bus.

### Good to know

One card holds one zone-type at a time, and one person at a time. Travelling as a couple? You need two cards. Staying a few days and using transport a lot? The **Andante Tour** (24h ≈ €7.75, 72h ≈ €17) is unlimited, all zones — simpler than counting trips.

## Money, tipping & the small stuff

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- **Cards everywhere**, but carry €20–30 in cash for the market, small cafés and tips.
- **Tipping is light**. Round up, or leave 5–10% for good service. No one expects 20%.
- **Tap water is safe** and good. You don't need to buy bottled.
- "**Bom dia / boa tarde / obrigado**" goes a long way. Locals warm up fast to anyone who tries.



DAY 1

1

# Old Porto & the River

The postcard Porto — but walked the way a local would, with the traps flagged and the good corners marked. Tiles, the cathedral, the bridge, and the river at golden hour.



# Down to the Douro

MORNING · FROM 9:30

## São Bento Station

Start where the city shows off. The main hall of **São Bento** is wrapped in some 20,000 blue-and-white azulejo tiles telling Portugal's history. It's a working train station, so it's free and open early — go before the tour groups land.

LATE MORNING

## The Cathedral & the climb down

Walk up to the **Sé do Porto**, the fortress-like cathedral. Skip the inside if you're short on time — the reason to come is the terrace view over the rooftops. From here, wander *down* the medieval lanes toward the river.

MIDDAY

## Ribeira — look, don't lunch

The riverfront **Ribeira** is gorgeous and you should see it. Just don't eat at the places with the river view and the photo menus — that's where prices double and quality drops.

### Skip this → do this

Hungry by the river? Walk two or three streets *back* from the water, away from the postcard, and you'll find small tascas where locals actually eat for half the price. The rule in any tourist city: the better the view from the table, the worse the food.

AFTERNOON · GOLDEN HOUR

## Cross the bridge — top deck

Walk the **Dom Luís I Bridge** across to Gaia. Take the **upper deck** (the metro level, safe for pedestrians) for the famous view — the river, the boats, the terracotta rooftops stacked up the hillside. This is the photo you came for.

EVENING

## Wine & sunset in Gaia

The far bank is lined with **port wine cellars** — Cálem, Graham's, Taylor's and more. A tour-and-tasting is touristy but genuinely worth doing once. Time it so you finish near sunset.

### Local tip

For the sunset itself, skip the crowded cellar terraces and climb to **Jardim do Morro** (right by the bridge, its own metro stop). Locals bring a drink, sit on the grass, and watch the light go gold over the whole city. Free, and better than any rooftop bar.





DAY 2

# 2

## Markets, Books & the Real City

The Porto that lives between the monuments — its market, its coffee houses, its art streets. Today is about texture, not landmarks. And yes, the famous bookshop, told honestly.



# The city between the sights

MORNING · FROM 9:00

## Mercado do Bolhão

The heart of working Porto, beautifully restored and reopened. Wander the stalls of the **tripeiras** — the traditional women vendors — selling fruit, flowers, fish and cheese. Grab a bag of *tremoços* (lupin beans) to snack on for a euro or two. Open Mon–Fri 8–20h, Sat 8–18h; closed Sundays.

### Good to know

Don't walk into the ground-floor fish section at 12:30 — it's a wet, elbow-to-elbow crush. Come earlier, or head upstairs where small restaurants serve an honest lunch over the market.

LATE MORNING

## Livraria Lello — the honest version

Yes, it's one of the most beautiful bookshops in the world: carved wood, a crimson staircase, stained glass. It's also packed and ticketed — entry is about **€10**, redeemable against a book. **Buy online in advance** to skip the worst of the queue, and go right at opening.

### Skip this → do this

Not into crowds? **Skip Lello** and visit **Livraria Chaminé da Mota** or browse the calmer shops around Rua das Flores instead. The magic of Lello is the building, not the books — if a 30-minute queue for a photo isn't your thing, you won't be missing the city's soul.

AFTERNOON

## Clérigos & the art streets

Pass the **Clérigos Tower** — climb it for the view, or just admire it from below and save your legs. Then drift into **Cedofeita** and **Rua Miguel Bombarda**, Porto's gallery district: independent shops, street art, third-wave coffee.

EVENING

## Francesinha, done right

Porto's monster sandwich — bread, cured meats, steak, melted cheese, drowned in a beer-and-tomato sauce, usually with an egg and fries. It's heavy, it's glorious, and it's a rite of passage. Go to a place locals rate (Café Santiago and Brasão are safe, popular bets) and order a small beer to cut through it.



DAY 3

3

# Sea, Sun & Slow Porto

The day most guides skip — and locals love most. The Atlantic, grilled fish by the harbour, gardens and modern art. Porto exhales by the ocean.





# Out to the ocean

## MORNING

### Foz do Douro

Take the vintage tram or a bus out to **Foz**, where the river meets the sea. Walk the seafront promenade past the little lighthouse and the **Pérgola da Foz**. Atlantic wind, crashing waves, joggers and dog-walkers — this is where Porto comes to breathe.

## MIDDAY

### Matosinhos — the real seafood lunch

A short hop north, **Matosinhos** is where locals go for fish. On and around **Rua Heróis de França**, simple restaurants grill the day's catch on charcoal out on the pavement. Point at what looks good, order a vinho verde, and don't overthink it. This is the best meal of the trip.

#### Good to know

Grilled fish is sold by weight, so the bill can surprise you. Ask the price before you commit, and the sardines or mackerel are as delicious as the pricier sea bass. Honest food, honest portions.

## AFTERNOON

### Serralves — art in a garden

Head to **Serralves**: a sleek contemporary art museum, a pink Art Deco villa, and 18 hectares of parkland. Even if modern art isn't your thing, the gardens alone are worth the afternoon. (Prefer music and architecture? Swap in **Casa da Música**.)

## EVENING · LAST NIGHT

### One more sunset

End where you began — back over the river. Find a miradouro, grab a final glass of something, and watch the city light up. You've earned it.

#### Local tip

This is the day to come back to anything you loved and rushed past. Three days is enough to *meet* Porto — not to finish it. That's the point: leave wanting to return.

# The local's shortlist

When you don't have time to read — just point at this.

## Eat like a local

Grilled fish in Matosinhos · a francesinha at Santiago or Brasão · petiscos (small plates) over a long dinner · pastéis de nata with an espresso (ask for *um café*).

## Best free views

Jardim do Morro at sunset · the Sé terrace · the top deck of Dom Luís I · the Foz seafront.

## Coffee & sweet

An espresso at the counter — ask for *um café*, drink it standing (cheaper) · Manteigaria for warm nata · the Bolhão upper floor · Cedofeita's specialty cafés.

## Rainy day

São Bento's tiles · Lello (booked ahead) · Serralves museum · a long lunch and a port tasting across the river.

## Tourist traps to skip

Riverfront Ribeira restaurants · anything with a photo menu and a tout at the door · overpriced "porto tonic" rooftop bars.

## Bring home

A bottle of tawny port · tinned fish (conservas) in pretty tins · soap from a classic Porto drugstore · a book from Lello (your ticket pays for it).

## Local tip

The single best souvenir is timing: go to the big sights right at opening or in the last hour of the day. Same place, half the crowd, twice the magic.

IF YOU HAVE MORE TIME

## Beyond the city

Four day-trips, each an easy train or drive from Porto — ranked by what kind of traveller you are.

### Douro Valley

The reason the wine exists. Terraced vineyards above a green river — arguably the most beautiful corner of Portugal. The train from São Bento to Pinhão is a scenic trip in itself. *For: wine, views, slowness.*

### Guimarães

"Portugal was born here" — a medieval town with a castle and a gorgeous old centre, ~1h by train. *For: history lovers.*

### Braga

Churches, fountains and the dramatic Bom Jesus do Monte stairway. Young, lively, very Portuguese. *For: culture and atmosphere.*

### Aveiro

The "Portuguese Venice" — canals, painted boats, candy-striped houses by the coast. Easy and charming. *For: a light, pretty half-day.*

### Local tip

Only have one extra day and can't choose? Take the **Douro**. The others are towns you'll find echoes of elsewhere; the Douro Valley you'll find nowhere else.

## A note on getting there

Guimarães, Braga and Aveiro are all reachable by inexpensive regional trains from Porto's **Campanhã** or **São Bento** stations. The Douro is loveliest by train to Pinhão, or as a guided trip if you'd rather not plan.

# Good to know

The boring page you'll be glad exists.

## If something goes wrong

- **Emergency (police, fire, medical):** 112 — free, works on any phone, English spoken.
- **Pharmacies (farmácias):** green cross sign; there's always a 24h one on rotation — the nearest pharmacy posts which.
- **Lost / stolen:** tourist police have a desk in the centre; your hotel can point you there.

## A few words that open doors

- **Olá / Bom dia** — Hello / Good morning
- **Obrigado** (men) · **Obrigada** (women) — Thank you
- **Por favor** — Please · **Desculpe** — Excuse me / sorry
- **A conta, por favor** — The bill, please
- **Um café** — An espresso. In Porto we say *café*, never "bica" — that's a Lisbon word, and ordering one marks you as a visitor.

## Rhythms of the city

Lunch runs roughly 12:30–15:00, dinner from 19:30 onward — restaurants can feel empty at 19:00 and full at 21:00. Many small places close Sundays or Mondays. Porto is generally very safe; use normal city sense in crowds and at night.

### Good to know

That bread, olives and cheese the waiter brings before you order? It's the *couvert* — not free. Eat it if you want it; wave it away politely if you don't. No offence taken.



# Obrigado.

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*I hope Porto treats you the way it's treated me —  
like home.*

This guide grows. The living version stays up to date, in six languages,  
free for everyone — at **[eyeofporto.github.io](https://eyeofporto.github.io)**. If it made your trip  
even a little better, you can leave a tip there, or just tell a friend. Both  
keep a local writing.

Questions, corrections, a great spot I missed? **[eyeofporto@gmail.com](mailto:eyeofporto@gmail.com)**